

Payment Rail Choice Doubles as a Maturity Signal

An evidence review of payment infrastructure across 1,000 verified-revenue startups

Headline finding

Stripe-billed companies show a median lifetime revenue of **\$8,738** — **103x** the \$85 median among companies on emerging payment rails.

Which payment API a founder connects reveals their stage before any survey does

01

Payment rail tracks company stage, not just billing preference

Median lifetime revenue steps from \$85 (emerging rails) to \$2,184 (mobile subscription infrastructure) to \$8,738 (Stripe) — a 103x range across three tiers.

02

Stripe is the default at scale

636 of 981 single-provider companies (65%) bill through Stripe, accounting for 88% of all 30-day revenue in the dataset.

03

RevenueCat and Superwall mark a distinct mobile-subscription economy

This group is 72% B2C and essentially 0% B2B, concentrated in Mobile Apps and Health & Fitness — a different business model from Stripe's balanced B2B/B2C SaaS mix.

04

The signal is free and available immediately

Payment-provider metadata alone can pre-segment a cohort by stage and business model, without waiting on a survey or a founder interview.

SO WHAT Use payment-provider metadata as a zero-cost first pass to segment startups by stage and business model.

We grouped payment providers into four tiers and tested them against maturity signals

Stripe

The general-purpose default for web software billing.

n = 636

Mobile infra

RevenueCat + Superwall — mobile subscription paywalls.

n = 206

Emerging rails

Dodo, Polar, Lemon Squeezy, Whop, Creem — newer indie processors.

n = 123

Other

Paddle — merchant-of-record billing, mixed profile.

n = 16

Method

- 981 of 1,000 companies report a single payment provider
- Maturity proxied by lifetime revenue and domain rating
- Medians used throughout; both metrics are heavily skewed

Known limitations

- No founding-date field — stage is inferred, not observed
- Superwall alone is n=17; read as directional, not robust
- 19 multi-provider companies excluded from clean comparison

SO WHAT Findings below describe an association between rail choice and stage — a useful proxy, not a causal mechanism.

Stripe is 65% of companies and 88% of revenue — the market is a lopsided default



READ ACROSS

Stripe over-indexes on revenue relative to its company share; emerging rails under-index by a wide margin.

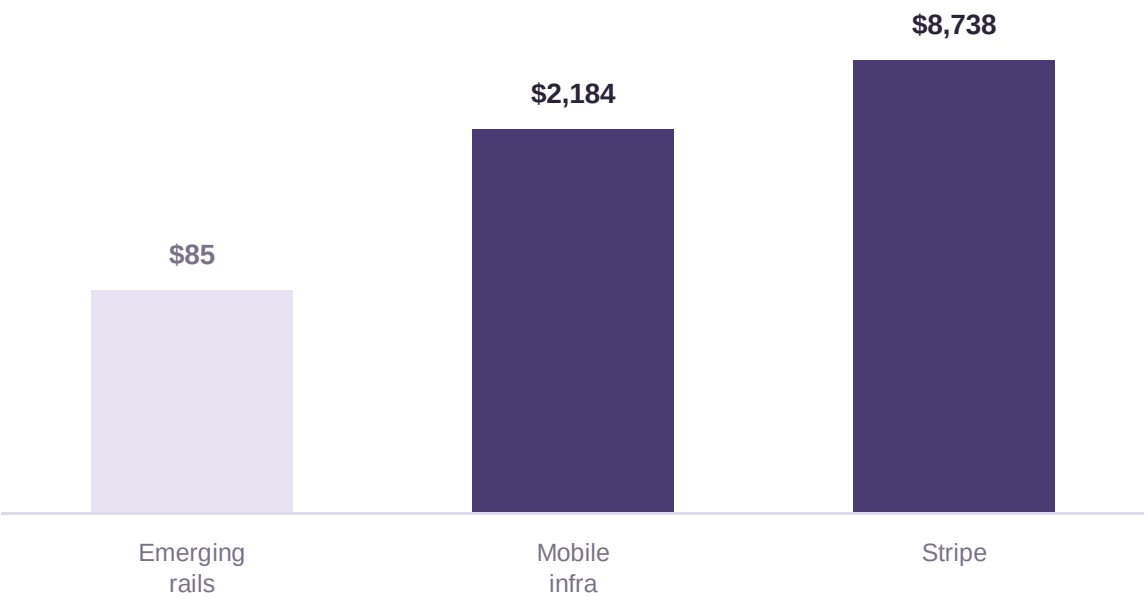
SO WHAT A company's payment rail is a rough but immediate read on how much revenue-scale it has likely reached.

Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 verified startups, frozen 30 Jul 2026. Team analysis.

Lifetime revenue and domain authority both step up in the same order across rails

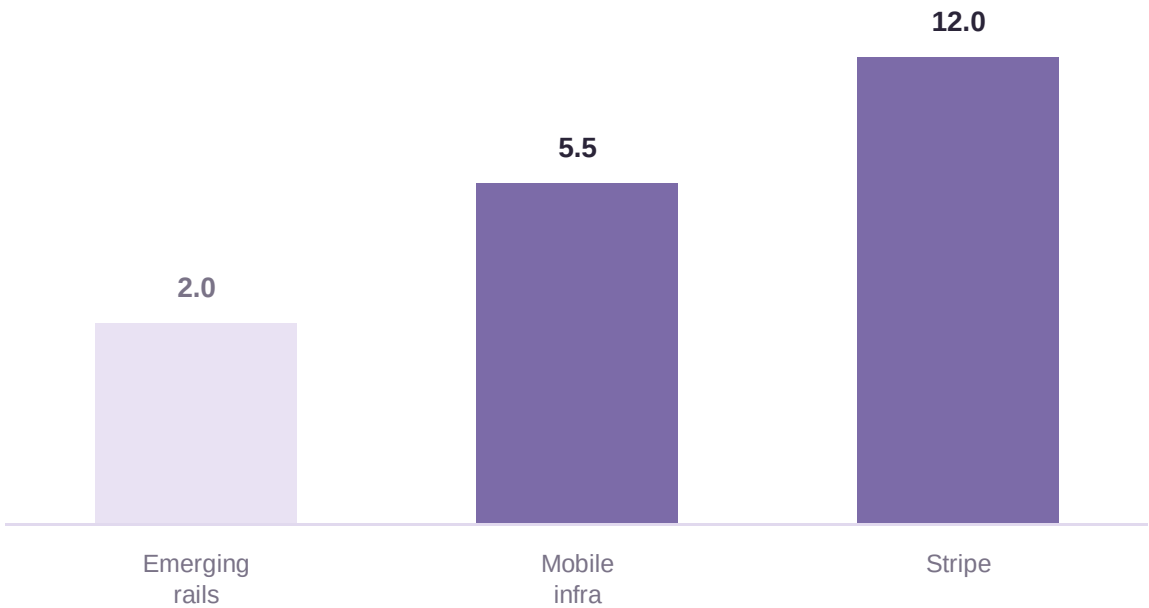
Median lifetime revenue by rail tier

Monotonic — every tier earns more than the one before it. Log scale.



Median domain rating by rail tier

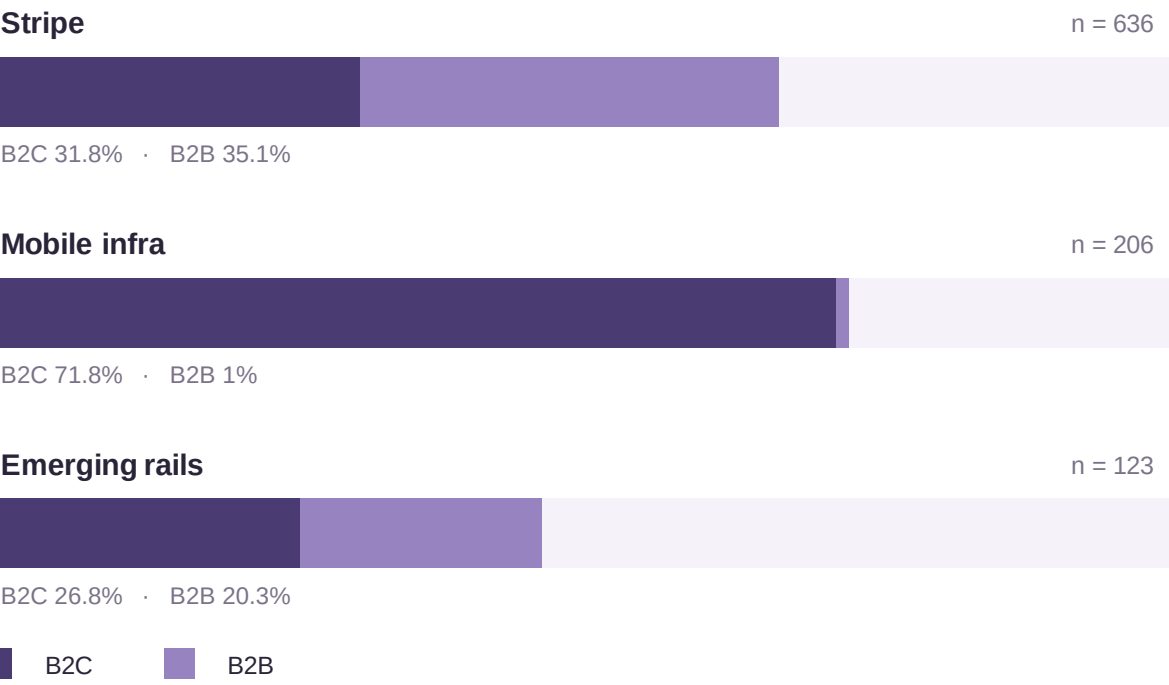
Same order, smaller range — a second, independent maturity signal.



SO WHAT Two independent metrics — revenue and domain authority — rank the three tiers in the same order.

Mobile infrastructure is a distinct economy, not just an earlier stage of the same one

Audience type by rail tier



Top categories by rail tier

- Stripe**
- AI, SaaS, Marketing
- Mobile infra**
- Mobile Apps, AI, Health & Fitness
- Emerging rails**
- AI, Productivity, SaaS
- Mobile infra is consumer-app territory; Stripe and emerging rails share the same software categories at different scale.*

SO WHAT Rail choice signals business model as much as stage: mobile infra is a different economy, not an earlier version of Stripe's.

What each payment rail tells you, at a glance

Rail tier	Reads as	Maturity signal	Audience	Coverage
Stripe	Established, broad software	High (\$8,738 lifetime med.)	Balanced B2B / B2C	636 of 981
Mobile infra	Scaling consumer app	Mid (\$2,184 lifetime med.)	72% B2C	206 of 981
Emerging rails	Early-stage / just launched	Low (\$85 lifetime med.)	Mixed, B2C-leaning	123 of 981
Other (Paddle)	Small, mixed profile	Directional only	Balanced	16 of 981

SO WHAT Three tiers, three distinguishable archetypes — legible from one metadata field, before any outreach happens.

Separating what the data establishes from what it merely suggests

ESTABLISHED BY THE DATA

- Lifetime revenue and domain rating both step up in the same order across the three rail tiers
- Stripe accounts for 88% of revenue from 65% of companies — a clear over-index
- Mobile infra is overwhelmingly B2C and concentrated in consumer categories, unlike Stripe or emerging rails
- Emerging-rail companies show the lowest revenue and domain authority of any tier, consistent with very early stage

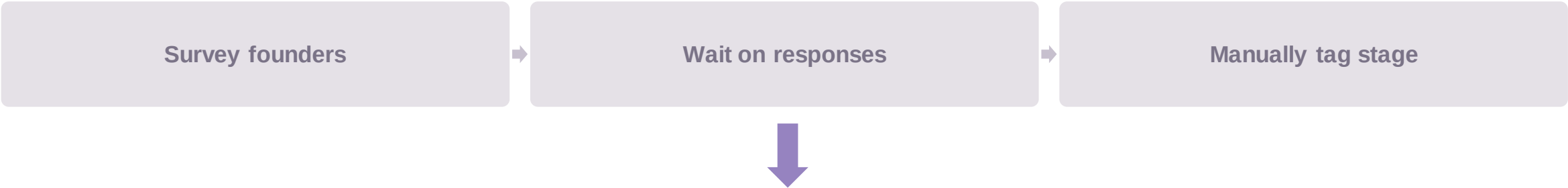
NOT ESTABLISHED — ARGUED

- That switching payment providers changes a company's stage. Rail choice is a marker of stage, not a lever on it
- That founding date or age is measured directly. No such field exists — stage is inferred from revenue and authority
- The Superwall-specific numbers, taken alone. $n=17$ is too small to generalise beyond the combined mobile-infra tier
- That this pattern holds outside self-selected, payment-key-verified founders on this platform

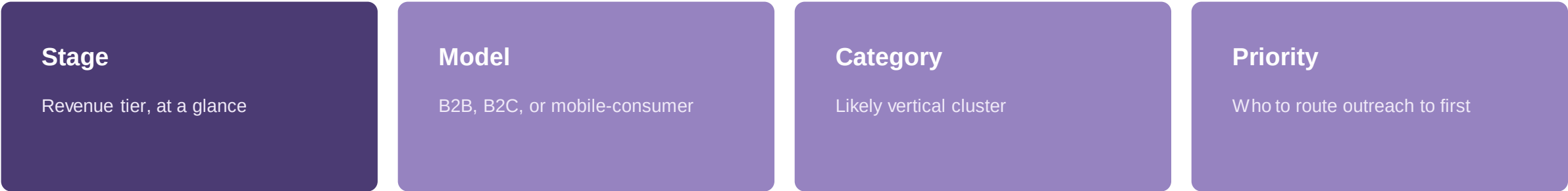
SO WHAT The recommendation stands on the left column alone; the right column is the argument built on top of it.

One metadata field does the work a founder survey would otherwise need to do

Conventional segmentation



What the payment field already gives you



SO WHAT A single existing field — payment provider — substitutes for a chunk of manual founder-cohort tagging.

Three moves the evidence supports

01

Use payment rail as a free first-pass filter

Before any outreach, sort prospective cohorts by payment provider to get a rough, zero-cost read on stage and likely revenue band.

Evidence: Exhibit 1, Exhibit 2

02

Treat mobile infra as a separate track, not an earlier Stripe

RevenueCat/Superwall companies are a distinct consumer-app economy. Curriculum, outreach, and benchmarks built for Stripe-style SaaS will not fit them.

Evidence: Exhibit 3

03

Watch emerging-rail adoption as an early-stage leading indicator

Dodo, Polar, Lemon Squeezy and similar rails cluster at the very earliest, lowest-revenue stage — useful for spotting brand-new cohorts first.

Evidence: Exhibit 2, Exhibit 4

SO WHAT None of this needs new data collection — only reading a field the dataset already has.

The billing stack a founder chooses is already telling you who they are.

Payment infrastructure is metadata the dataset already has — and a proxy for stage this analysis shows is worth reading.